

The Instability Itself Is the Institution: Ministerial Survival and Institutional Learning in Peru, 1821–2026

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Abstract

Why do political systems that change so much change so little in how they govern? This paper addresses that question through an original dataset of 1,062 ministerial spells covering five portfolios in Peru from 1821 to 2026. Rather than treating ministerial duration as the outcome to be explained, we treat it as a signal: an observable trace of the continuity conditions under which governing experience either accumulates into institutional knowledge or is repeatedly lost. We organize the analysis around two analytical heuristics. The first is the institutional epoch — the path-dependent period between critical junctures — which captures whether successive historical ruptures produced durable improvements in continuity conditions. The second is the protective belt — a localized architecture of external accountability relationships that, where it exists, insulates certain ministries from the political logic governing the rest of the cabinet. Kaplan–Meier survival curves, log-rank tests, and Cox proportional hazards models show that epochs explain ministerial survival far better than individual traits or portfolio membership, and that continuity conditions did not improve monotonically across two centuries. The largest shift in the data occurred between the Oligarchic State and the Power-Sharing epoch; the most recent democratic period represents a partial regression toward the founding pattern of chronic interruption. The protective belt emerges only after 1993, when external accountability structures raised the cost of Economy minister replacement beyond what domestic political pressure alone could sustain. The central theoretical finding is that chronic ministerial instability in Peru is not evidence of absent institutions but of a durable informal one: the escape valve through which political pressure is absorbed without producing structural change. The instability itself is the institution.

“Se vogliamo che tutto rimanga
com’è, bisogna che tutto cambi.”

Il Gattopardo
Giuseppe Tomasi di Lampedusa,
1958

Introduction

Governing is hard. Education, health, and public safety are not technical problems with known solutions — they are complex social challenges that resist quick fixes and demand sustained institutional effort. Good policy takes time to design, time to implement, and more time still to reach the people it is meant to serve. Good practices percolate gradually. Organizations learn slowly. Citizens feel change only after years of consistent effort in the same direction. In the big picture, where governance improved, it did so through institutional correction after crisis — converting rupture into consolidation, learning from failure rather than repeating it.

After more than two hundred years of republican life, the Peruvian political class has repeatedly changed governments, cabinets, constitutions, and political coalitions. Yet the underlying pattern remains remarkably stable. Each new administration appoints a cabinet whose members understand, implicitly or explicitly, the terms of their engagement: they are expected to manage complexity on behalf of the leader, but they may also be sacrificed whenever political pressure demands a visible response. Their departure rarely resolves the conflict that triggered it. The resignation of a premier or any other minister may relieve immediate pressure, but it seldom addresses the underlying causes of crisis. Cabinet reshuffles signal responsiveness without necessarily producing institutional correction.

This persistence should not be mistaken for an absence of learning. Political actors adapt continuously. Over time, they have become increasingly adept at navigating constitutional ambiguities, managing blame, and deploying ministerial replacement as a mechanism for absorbing public dissatisfaction. If the political class has learned anything, it has been how to reproduce the system’s response to crisis rather than how to transform it. Governments change. Ministers change. The repertoire through which instability is managed remains largely intact. This cycle has marked much of Peru’s republican history.

This vicious circle is generally called path dependence — a sophisticated way to say that the inertia of accumulated choices makes deviation increasingly costly and increasingly unlikely. And yet paths do break. Oxford philosopher Roman Krznaric (2024) argues that radical change requires what he calls the disruption nexus: a crisis, disruptive movements that amplify it, and powerful ideas that are ready to fill the space the crisis opens. France’s Fifth Republic had all three: the Algerian War as crisis, De Gaulle’s movement as disruptive force, and a constitutional design — the

strong executive — as the idea ready to be deployed. It was not one event that broke France’s path. It was a multigenerational accumulation of chronic instability that the Third and Fourth Republics never resolved. The Fifth Republic became the enduring legacy of a critical juncture in French history. More importantly, it appears to have altered the conditions under which political continuity was produced. The result was not merely institutional change, but a durable shift in the patterns of executive stability that had characterized French politics for more than a century.

France, before the Fifth Republic, was not very different from Peru during the previous hundred years. Both experienced remarkably high levels of executive instability, reflected in similar numbers of premier appointments per decade. Figure 1 tells the story visually. Peru peaked at 23 appointments in the 1890s; France reached 20 in the 1930s. Yet the advent of the Fifth Republic in 1958 initiated sharply diverging trajectories. French premier appointments fell to a stable band of three to six per decade and have remained there ever since, while Peru is returning to levels observed in the nineteenth century. Peru has experienced no shortage of potential disruption nexuses — or, as we will later call them, critical junctures: independence without state-building, the War of the Pacific, hyperinflation, terrorism, the fall of Fujimori, and a permanent constitutional crisis since 2016. Each represented a moment in which alternative institutional trajectories became plausible.

The question, however, is not whether institutional change occurred. Peru’s republican history is full of reforms, constitutions, regime transitions, and political ruptures. The question is whether those ruptures produced institutional learning. By institutional learning, we mean the capacity of an institutional order to generate more favorable conditions for preserving, accumulating, and transmitting political experience over time. From this perspective, a critical juncture is successful not simply because it produces a new institutional arrangement, but because it leaves behind a legacy that alters how the system responds to future crises. France appears to have experienced such a transformation after 1958. Peru’s trajectory raises the possibility that institutional change and institutional learning do not necessarily coincide.

I approach institutional learning through ministerial duration data using the heuristic of institutional epochs. Within epochs, duration provides evidence about the conditions under which knowledge accumulates; across epochs, changes in those patterns provide evidence about institutional learning. Political science has traditionally studied these phenomena separately. Ministerial duration has been analyzed through the tools of survival and event-history analysis, while institutional change has been examined through the comparative-historical literature on critical junctures and path dependence. This paper combines both traditions. It uses ministerial duration data to evaluate whether critical junctures produced enduring changes in the conditions under which political experience accumulates.

The *epoch* heuristic is the institutional period that encompasses one or more presidential administrations and is defined by the critical junctures that periodically restructure the state’s political logic. Epochs capture what neither individual traits

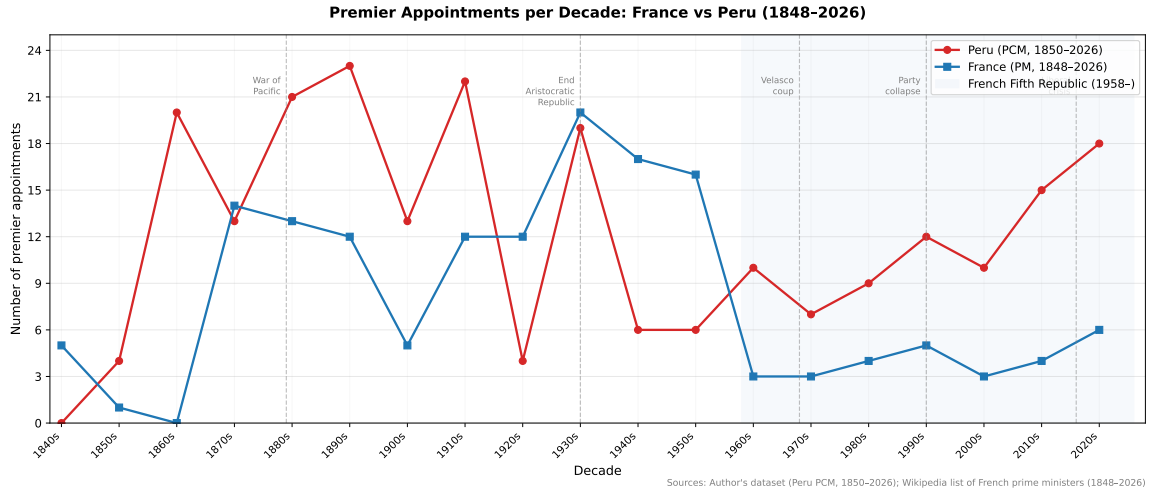


Figure 1

Premier Appointments per Decade: France vs. Peru, 1848–2026.

Sources: Author's dataset (based on Gálvez Montero and García Vega (2016a, 2016b)); Wikipedia list of French prime ministers (1848–2026).

nor political context alone can explain: the continuity conditions under which experience is either accumulated or repeatedly lost. If institutional learning occurs, it should be observable through changes in those conditions across successive epochs.

Within epochs, this work conceptualizes a second analytical heuristic, the *protective belt*: an *ad hoc* architecture of rules, actors, and external accountability relationships that, where it exists, helps preserve continuity despite the political logic governing the rest of the cabinet. By protecting continuity, the belt creates opportunities for knowledge accumulation within epochs and may allow certain sectors to function as islands of institutional effectiveness within a broader environment of instability. The protective belt does not explain institutional learning at the level of the state as a whole. Rather, it explains why some ministries may accumulate knowledge and preserve continuity even when the broader institutional environment remains unfavorable.

The question guiding this study is straightforward: *Have Peru's critical junctures ever produced institutional learning?*

This question cannot be answered directly. Institutional learning is not observed in the data. Instead, the study approaches the question indirectly through patterns of ministerial duration. If institutional learning improves the conditions under which political experience accumulates and is preserved, then such improvements should be reflected in changes in ministerial continuity across institutional epochs. Ministerial duration therefore provides an approximate indicator of the continuity conditions from which institutional learning may emerge.

The theoretical framework developed in this paper distinguishes between

knowledge accumulation within institutional epochs and institutional learning across them. This distinction allows the central question to be translated into three empirical questions that can be addressed with duration data. *First*, what continuity conditions for knowledge accumulation characterized each institutional epoch? *Second*, did those continuity conditions change across successive epochs in ways consistent with institutional learning, or did critical junctures repeatedly reproduce the same underlying pattern of ministerial instability? *Third*, do some sectors of the state systematically escape the continuity conditions of their epoch, exhibiting survival patterns consistent with the presence of a protective belt, and if so, what does their existence reveal about the broader dynamics of continuity, knowledge accumulation, and institutional effectiveness?

To answer these questions, we construct an original dataset of individual ministerial spells covering the period from 1821 to 2026. The dataset includes the portfolios most relevant to the argument developed here: the premier, who coordinates the cabinet and sustains the political viability of the executive; the economy minister, whose decisions shape the state’s fiscal and investment capacity; and the ministers of Interior, Health, and Education, whose portfolios address some of the most consequential and persistent public challenges facing the country, according to official yearly surveys (INEI, 2024). The spells are organized into six institutional epochs defined by the critical junctures that periodically restructured Peru’s political logic (Lopez Jimenez et al., 2025). Combining descriptive analysis with survival models, the study evaluates whether patterns of ministerial continuity reveal different conditions for knowledge accumulation within epochs, whether those conditions changed across successive epochs, and whether some sectors exhibit continuity patterns consistent with the presence of a protective belt.

1 Literature Review

The political science literature on ministerial survival has converged around two broad families of explanations. The first emphasizes the characteristics of ministers themselves. The second emphasizes the political and institutional environments within which ministers operate. Table 1 summarizes the principal covariates identified across the core studies.

1.1 Trait-Based Explanations of Ministerial Survival

Trait-based approaches explain ministerial survival through characteristics of the officeholder. Across different institutional settings, scholars have shown that ministers’ professional backgrounds, political careers, partisan affiliations, and personal resources influence their probability of remaining in office. Early studies emphasized broad distinctions between managerial and parliamentary profiles, as well as the effects of career trajectories and prior political experience (Blondel, 1988). Subsequent work expanded the range of relevant characteristics to include age, education, gender,

Table 1*Trait-based and Context-based Predictors of Ministerial Survival*

Author(s)	Trait-based	Context-based
Blondel (1988)	Career duration; parliamentary vs. managerial profile	Party system norms; head-of-government style; country context
Huber & Martínez-Gallardo (2008)	Ideological distance from government center; PM party membership; portfolio importance	Coalition type; minority government; electoral volatility; party fractionalization
Dewan & Dowding (2005)	Resignation issue salience; ministerial seniority	PM support level; media attention; single-party vs. coalition system
Fischer et al. (2012)	Age; education; gender; portfolio rank	PM popularity; regime type; frequency of resignation calls
Camerlo & Pérez-Liñán (2015)	Portfolio type; technocrat/partisan/outsider profile; first cabinet appointment	Protests; scandals; electoral calendar; term limits; reelection rules
Camerlo & Castaldo (2024)	Partisan rank within party hierarchy (leader, high-rank, low-rank, newcomer, shadow, defector)	Party government model applicability; regime type; party institutionalization level
Feliú Ribeiro & López Burian (2023)	Technical expertise; presidential group membership; prior electoral experience (<i>risk factor</i>)	Economic growth; GDP per capita; legislative powers; regime type; portfolio area
Mejía et al. (2021)	Education; gender; regional origin; prior elected office	Coalition type; legislative majority; party system change
Alexiadou & Gunaydin (2019)	Technocratic profile; non-partisan status; reform commitment	Economic crisis severity; electoral system type; party control of portfolio
Baturo & Elkink (2014)	Personal traits as time-invariant officeholder effects (education, prior career)	Regime institutionalization; personalization vs. office-based authority
Jara Iñiguez & Cedeño Alcívar (2019)	Managerial performance lifecycle (inverted-U over tenure)	Presidential appointment and dismissal capacity; political trust as selection criterion

portfolio rank, and seniority within government (Dewan & Dowding, 2005; Fischer et al., 2012).

More recent research has refined these categories by focusing on the organizational and political resources that ministers bring to office. Feliú Ribeiro and López Burian show that technical expertise and membership in presidential networks increase ministerial survival, while prior electoral experience may paradoxically operate as a risk factor (Feliú Ribeiro & López Burian, 2023). Across four Latin American countries between 1945 and 2020, career politicians proved more vulnerable to dismissal than technocrats. The finding suggests that ministerial value cannot be reduced to political experience alone; survival depends on the type of resources that political leaders seek to preserve.

The literature has also moved beyond simple dichotomies between partisan and non-partisan ministers. Camerlo and Castaldo argue that partisan affiliation conceals substantial variation in the strength of a minister's relationship with the party organization. Their framework distinguishes among leaders, high-ranks, low-ranks, newcomers, shadows, and defectors according to levels of engagement, consolidation, and hierarchical position within the party (Camerlo & Castaldo, 2024). Applied to the Argentine cabinet under Alberto Fernández, this approach reveals that apparently strong partisan cabinets may actually consist of ministers with limited organizational leverage over their parties (Camerlo et al., 2024). For survival analysis, the implica-

tion is straightforward: ministers classified under the same partisan label may possess very different capacities to resist political pressure.

Taken together, these studies demonstrate that ministerial duration is shaped by who ministers are. Technical expertise, organizational embeddedness, political experience, and personal resources all influence survival prospects. Yet the significance of these traits depends on the environments in which ministers operate. The same characteristic may be rewarded in one institutional setting and penalized in another. This observation leads to the second major family of explanations.

1.2 Context-Based Explanations of Ministerial Survival

Context-based approaches explain ministerial survival through characteristics of the political environment rather than characteristics of individual ministers. In this perspective, ministers survive or fail because of the institutional and political constraints surrounding them.

The comparative literature consistently identifies coalition dynamics as a central determinant of ministerial duration. Coalition type, minority government status, electoral volatility, and party-system fragmentation all shape the likelihood of ministerial replacement independently of individual characteristics (Huber & Martínez-Gallardo, 2008). Similarly, political crises, scandals, protests, electoral calendars, and term limits alter the incentives presidents face when deciding whether to retain or dismiss ministers (Alexiadou & Gunaydin, 2019; Camerlo & Pérez-Liñán, 2015). Even macroeconomic performance influences survival probabilities by modifying the broader political environment within which governments operate (Feliú Ribeiro & López Burian, 2023).

The case literature illustrates these mechanisms particularly clearly. For Colombia, Mejía Guinand et al. find that individual characteristics matter, but the institutional configuration of the political system ultimately determines the range within which those characteristics can operate (Mejía et al., 2021). Constitutional reforms, changes in party-system structure, and coalition arrangements alter the political logic governing ministerial careers. A similar conclusion emerges from Chile. Avendaño and Dávila show that ministerial turnover during the Concertación governments was driven primarily by coalition management considerations rather than by individual performance. Finance ministers consistently exhibited the longest tenures regardless of personal characteristics (Avendaño & Dávila, 2012).

Recent work has also refined the contextual analysis of ministerial portfolios. Portfolio importance has traditionally been measured through expert rankings that assign ministries a single level of salience. Camerlo and Martínez-Gallardo argue that such measures obscure important differences among ministries, particularly in contexts characterized by weak party institutionalization (Camerlo & Gallardo, 2022). Their framework decomposes ministerial value into policy-management capacity, discretionary resource allocation, political agenda influence, and inter-portfolio coordination authority. Different political environments activate different dimensions of

portfolio value, producing distinct survival incentives for presidents and ministers alike.

Taken together, these studies show that ministerial survival depends not only on who ministers are but also on where they operate. Institutional structures, coalition arrangements, political crises, economic conditions, and portfolio characteristics shape the opportunities and constraints governing ministerial careers.

1.3 Reinterpreting Ministerial Duration

The two families of explanations are not competing research programs. Virtually every study combines individual and contextual covariates, with political environments conditioning the effects of ministerial traits. The resulting literature has generated a rich understanding of why some ministers survive longer than others.

What the literature has not asked is a prior question: what patterns of survival reveal about the continuity conditions through which political experience is collectively preserved, accumulated, and transmitted over time. Existing studies treat duration as the outcome to be explained. This paper treats duration as evidence about the institutional conditions that sustain continuity. Rather than asking why one minister survives longer than another, we ask what patterns of ministerial continuity reveal about the environments within which political experience can accumulate over time.

The next section develops a theoretical framework linking continuity, knowledge accumulation, and institutional learning, and introduces critical junctures and institutional epochs as the analytical devices through which those processes can be studied historically.

2 Theoretical Framework

2.1 From Ministerial Survival to Institutional Learning

The literature reviewed above treats ministerial survival as the outcome to be explained. This paper treats it as a signal. What survival time carries, we argue, is information about a prior and more consequential process: the accumulation of institutional knowledge within the state. A foundational claim of organizational learning theory is that institutions outperform alternatives when they successfully encode inferences from experience into routines that guide future behavior (Levitt & March, 1988, pp. 319–320). For this to occur, experience must first persist long enough to be accumulated, shared, and embedded within organizations. Ministerial stability is therefore not valuable in itself. Rather, it constitutes a necessary condition for the accumulation of knowledge from which broader processes of institutional learning may subsequently emerge (Nonaka, 1998).

For the purposes of this paper, it is useful to distinguish between **knowledge accumulation** and **institutional learning**. Knowledge accumulation refers to the process through which experience is retained, articulated, shared, and embedded

within organizations. Institutional learning refers to the capacity of an institutional order to generate progressively more favorable conditions for the accumulation, retention, and transmission of experience over time. The two concepts are related but distinct. Knowledge accumulation occurs within organizations and within institutional epochs. Institutional learning becomes visible when successive institutional orders improve the conditions under which such accumulation can occur.

This distinction draws on a common insight running through the literature reviewed below. For Nonaka, learning requires the successful conversion of experience into organizational knowledge (Nonaka, 1998). For Simon, organizations learn when they develop more effective ways of structuring and responding to complex problems (Foss & Foss, 2005). For Allison, learning becomes visible when experience is embedded in routines that guide future action (Allison, 1969). Across these perspectives, learning implies more than isolated episodes of knowledge creation. It implies the development of conditions that allow experience to be retained and used rather than repeatedly lost.

This distinction has important implications for interpretation. Survival is not treated as a direct measure of either knowledge accumulation or institutional learning. A long ministerial tenure does not demonstrate that knowledge accumulated, just as a short tenure does not prove that accumulation failed. Rather, survival is interpreted as an observable indicator of continuity. Continuity creates opportunities for knowledge accumulation. Institutional learning, by contrast, becomes visible when successive institutional orders generate more favorable conditions for such accumulation over time. What survival time reveals, therefore, is not learning itself but the extent to which institutional continuity creates opportunities for experience to accumulate. Reading survival as a signal of continuity has one methodological implication that separates this paper from the existing literature. Duration cannot be modeled as a homogeneous process pooled across history. If continuity is the mechanism through which knowledge accumulates, then the relevant question is whether the conditions supporting that accumulation changed over time. This requires analytical cut points corresponding to moments when the institutional logic governing political life was transformed. Such moments are identified through the critical-juncture framework developed below. Critical junctures delimit institutional epochs, and epochs constitute the historical environments within which continuity either facilitates knowledge accumulation or repeatedly interrupts it. More importantly, epochs provide the interpretive context through which continuity acquires meaning. The same observed duration may imply very different continuity conditions depending on the political logic, constraints, and expectations characterizing a particular epoch. Assessing institutional learning therefore requires interpreting continuity relative to the historical environment in which it is produced rather than according to a universal benchmark.

Consequently, the objective of this study is not to determine whether individual ministers learned, nor whether particular appointments were successful. Instead, it evaluates whether different institutional epochs generated different continuity condi-

tions and, therefore, different opportunities for knowledge accumulation. Ministerial survival serves as the observable trace of those conditions. The question is not why ministers survive, but what patterns of survival reveal about the state's capacity to accumulate and preserve experience across successive historical periods.

The remainder of the theoretical framework develops this argument in three steps. First, it explains the mechanisms through which continuity enables knowledge accumulation within institutional epochs. Second, it examines how changes in those continuity conditions across epochs can be interpreted as evidence of institutional learning. Third, it introduces the concept of the protective belt to explain why some ministries may experience continuity conditions that differ from those prevailing in the broader institutional environment. Throughout the discussion, **arrows** ($\rightarrow$) are used as heuristic representations of hypothesized causal influence. They indicate a proposed direction of influence but do not imply a specific sign, magnitude, or deterministic effect.

2.2 Knowledge Accumulation Within Epochs

If ministerial duration is interpreted as a signal of continuity, the first theoretical task is to explain how continuity contributes to knowledge accumulation. The question is therefore straightforward: what mechanisms allow governing experience to accumulate, and what mechanisms interrupt that process?

The argument developed here begins with a simple proposition: knowledge accumulation depends on continuity over time. Drawing on Nonaka, knowledge creation is not a single event but a cumulative process through which tacit knowledge becomes explicit, is shared within the organization, and is eventually internalized into routines and practices (Nonaka, 1998). New knowledge emerges through repeated interaction among organizational members, the articulation of experience into formal procedures, and the gradual incorporation of those procedures into everyday behavior. The process cannot be compressed into a single decision, nor can it survive repeated interruptions without loss.

Continuity $\rightarrow$ Knowledge Accumulation

The first connection links Nonaka's theory of knowledge creation to Cohen, March, and Olsen's theory of organized anarchy. Organized anarchies are characterized by problematic preferences, unclear technology, and fluid participation (Cohen et al., 1972). High ministerial turnover operationalizes fluid participation at the cabinet level: decision-makers are replaced before they can develop a shared understanding of the problems they were appointed to address. From a causal perspective, fluid participation weakens continuity by preventing the emergence of the shared cognitive environment required for knowledge creation.

Fluid Participation $\rightarrow$ Continuity

The second connection links Nonaka's model to Simon's theory of bounded

rationality. Complex policy problems initially present themselves as ill-structured and become manageable only through gradual processes of problem decomposition and constraint formation (Foss & Foss, 2005, pp. 4–5). When ministers confront complex social challenges, their understanding is initially tacit. For organizations to benefit from that experience, tacit knowledge must be articulated, codified, and transformed into explicit knowledge that can be communicated and shared. This transformation requires time. Premature dismissal interrupts the conversion process and leaves accumulated experience personal rather than institutional.

Knowledge Articulation → Knowledge Accumulation

The third connection links Nonaka’s model to Allison’s organizational process perspective. Governments respond to recurring problems through standard operating procedures that have been developed through prior experience (Allison, 1969). Once knowledge has been articulated and formalized, it must be repeatedly applied before it becomes embedded in organizational routines. Chronic turnover disrupts this final stage by preventing newly created knowledge from stabilizing within organizational practice.

Knowledge Accumulation → Routine Formation

From this perspective, organizational routines constitute the institutional repository through which accumulated knowledge survives individual officeholders.

Routine Formation → Organizational Memory

Taken together, these perspectives describe a common mechanism of failure. Cohen, March, and Olsen explain why the social conditions required for knowledge creation may never emerge. Simon explains why the articulation of knowledge requires sustained attention to complex problems. Allison explains why newly created knowledge must be embedded in routines before organizations can benefit from it. Nonaka provides the connective logic linking these processes. The result is a single causal argument: continuity enables the articulation, accumulation, and retention of knowledge, while chronic turnover repeatedly interrupts each stage of the process.

Within Epochs:

Continuity → **Knowledge Accumulation** → Organizational Memory

2.3 Institutional Learning Between Epochs

The previous section explained how knowledge accumulates within institutional epochs. Institutional learning, however, refers to something different. It concerns whether the conditions governing knowledge accumulation themselves change over time. If continuity facilitates the retention of experience within epochs, insti-

tutional learning becomes visible when successive institutional orders generate more favorable conditions for that continuity.

Explaining such changes requires a theory of historical discontinuity. The comparative-historical literature provides such a framework through the concept of the critical juncture.

Critical junctures are defined as relatively short periods of time during which there is a substantially heightened probability that agents' choices will affect the outcome of interest (Capoccia & Kelemen, 2007, p. 348). These brief moments of structural fluidity are followed by long periods of path-dependent institutional reproduction, in which the choices made during the juncture become increasingly difficult to reverse. The standard application of this framework identifies a formal institution created or transformed at the juncture and traces its reproduction across the subsequent path. For our purposes, the implication is theoretical: if knowledge accumulates or is repeatedly interrupted within institutional periods, then the appropriate unit of analysis is the epoch — the path-dependent phase between junctures — rather than the presidential term or the individual ministerial spell.

Critical Juncture → Institutional Epoch

Capoccia introduces a further concept that proves essential for the framework: the near-miss critical juncture. Because critical junctures are defined by contingency — by what happened in the context of what could have happened — it is entirely possible for a crisis to produce a moment of genuine institutional openness that is ultimately resolved through re-equilibration rather than change (Capoccia & Kelemen, 2007, pp. 350–351). The previous institutional arrangement is reinstated, often in modified form, and the path continues. Critical junctures may therefore fail to alter the conditions governing knowledge accumulation. Institutional change can occur without a corresponding transformation in learning conditions.

This observation creates a theoretical puzzle. If formal institutions are repeatedly transformed, disrupted, or replaced, in what sense can one speak of path dependence at all? Levitsky and Murillo argue that in much of the developing world actors develop expectations of instability rather than expectations of institutional reproduction (Levitsky & Murillo, 2009, p. 123). Yet from the perspective developed here, the relevant question is not whether formal institutions remain unchanged, but whether the conditions governing knowledge accumulation persist across time. Informal mechanisms may survive repeated formal transformations and thereby reproduce the same learning conditions across successive epochs.

Institutional learning becomes visible when critical junctures alter the continuity conditions governing knowledge accumulation in durable ways. A sequence of critical junctures followed by increasingly favorable conditions for continuity would suggest institutional learning. A sequence of critical junctures followed by repeated interruptions or unchanged continuity conditions would suggest its absence. The key theoretical question is therefore whether successive institutional epochs generated

different opportunities for knowledge accumulation.

Between Epochs:

Critical Juncture → Institutional Epoch → **Institutional Learning**

2.4 The Exception That Tests the Rule: The Protective Belt

The previous sections described the general mechanisms governing knowledge accumulation within epochs and institutional learning across them. Yet continuity conditions are not necessarily distributed uniformly throughout the state. Some ministries may experience survival patterns that differ systematically from those prevailing in the broader institutional environment. Explaining such variation requires an additional mechanism.

The concept proposed here is the Protective Belt¹. The belt functions as a buffer that absorbs pressures that would otherwise interrupt continuity. It consists of informal rules, external actors, and accountability relationships that raise the political cost of ministerial replacement and thereby reduce the likelihood that continuity will be interrupted.

The protective belt is not necessarily attached to a particular ministry across time. Because critical junctures restructure the political logic of an institutional epoch, they may also alter which functions of the state become most essential to the reproduction of the institutional order. Consequently, different epochs may generate protective belts around different sectors. The object of protection is therefore expected to vary historically according to the dominant threats, audiences, and accountability relationships characterizing each institutional order.

Protective Belt → Continuity → **Knowledge Accumulation**

Comparative evidence suggests that such protection may emerge around specific portfolios under particular accountability structures. Feliú Ribeiro and López Burian demonstrate that foreign policy portfolios survive significantly longer than domestic portfolios across Latin America (Feliú Ribeiro & López Burian, 2023). The mechanism they identify is external accountability. International audiences create credibility costs that presidents must absorb when replacing ministers, thereby increasing continuity independently of domestic political pressures.

The protective belt is therefore not a veto player, nor a form of social capital. It is a cost structure that alters the incentives surrounding ministerial replacement.

¹The term "protective belt" is borrowed from Lakatos's philosophy of science, where it refers to a surrounding structure that shields a program's core assumptions from immediate falsification (Lakatos, 1978). The concept is used here metaphorically to denote institutional arrangements that protect continuity from political pressures.

Its presence or absence determines whether the continuity conditions experienced by a ministry differ from those prevailing in the broader institutional environment.

The Protective Belt does not explain institutional learning at the level of the state as a whole. Rather, it explains why some ministries may accumulate knowledge and preserve continuity even when broader learning conditions remain unfavorable. It is a localized continuity-preserving mechanism that may create islands of effectiveness without altering the broader learning conditions of the institutional order.

3 Research Design and Analytical Strategy

3.1 Institutional Epochs as Units of Historical Comparison

The theoretical framework distinguishes between knowledge accumulation within institutional epochs and institutional learning across them. Table 2 summarizes the institutional epochs employed in the analysis.

The epochs summarized above are not merely chronological containers. Each represents a distinct institutional environment governing the conditions under which political experience could be accumulated, transmitted, or interrupted. Following Lopez Jimenez et al. (2025), they are defined as path-dependent periods bounded by critical junctures that restructured the dominant logic of state organization and political competition. The critical-juncture column identifies the process that opened each epoch, while the cut-point column identifies the year used to delimit epochs in the empirical analysis. These cut points correspond to the completion of the critical juncture rather than to its onset, ensuring continuous temporal coverage of ministerial spells while avoiding the assignment of transitional years to a stable institutional order.

If institutional learning occurred across Peru’s republican history, it should be observable through changes in continuity conditions across these successive epochs. A sequence of epochs generating progressively longer ministerial survival would suggest improving learning conditions; a sequence reproducing the same patterns of interruption would suggest their absence. Because the present study evaluates institutional learning through changes in continuity conditions across completed epochs, the post-2022 period is analyzed separately as an ongoing process rather than as a consolidated institutional epoch.

3.2 Why Not Constitutional Periods or Regime Types?

Two alternative periodization strategies present themselves naturally and deserve explicit consideration. The first would organize ministerial spells by constitutional period. Peru has enacted thirteen constitutions since independence, each representing a formal institutional rupture. The second would organize spells by regime type — distinguishing democratic from authoritarian or military periods — following the approach standard in comparative survival studies (Feliú Ribeiro & López Burian, 2023).

Table 2

Institutional Epochs Used in the Analysis

Epoch	Period	End Point used	Critical Juncture	State and Democratization	Why It Ends
State Formation	1824–1879	1883	Independence (1810–1824). Liberal failure in state building; caudillo factionalism; colonial continuities intact.	Failed creole revolutions; indigenous participation conditioned on tribute abolition; no unified national state.	The War of the Pacific (1879) exposes the total absence of a functional national state.
Oligarchic State	1883–1920	1933	War with Chile (1879–1883). Humiliated elites; demonstrated inexistence of a functional state.	Patrimonial reconstruction under oligarchic-gamonalista alliance; “competitive oligarchy” excluding 98% of population; early anarchist labor movement.	Popular mobilizations and Leguía’s self-coup trigger the Crisis of the Aristocratic Republic (1920–1933).
Power-Sharing State	1933–1968	1975	Crisis of the Aristocratic Republic (1920–1933). Leguía, the 1930 recession, Haya, Mariátegui, assassination of Sánchez Cerro.	Tripartite system: oligarchy, APRA, and armed forces. After 1956, “convivencia” (APRA-oligarchy alliance); mass labor, peasant, and student movements emerge.	Social overflow and state paralysis trigger the Military Revolution (1968).
Transition and Democratic Crisis	1975–1992	1993	Military Revolution (1968–1975). Destroyed oligarchy and gamonalismo through agrarian reform; centralized the state.	Universal suffrage (1979 Constitution); democratization through Shining Path massacre; collapse of the United Left. Hyperinflation and state terrorism against insurgency.	Absolute crisis of political parties, hyperinflation, and terrorist violence culminate in Fujimori’s self-coup (1992).
Democracy without Parties	1993–2022	2022	Terrorism crisis, hyperinflation, and Fujimori’s coup (1982–1992).	1993 Constitution; consolidated neoliberal model and neopatrimonial state; long commodity export boom legitimizes the arrangement. Democracy without parties; extreme electoral volatility; <i>outsider</i> politics.	Political fall of Pedro Castillo (2022), condensing 30 years of discontent with the neoliberal model, opens the Sixth Critical Juncture.

Source: Adapted from Lopez Jimenez et al. (2025). Cut points indicate the years used to delimit epochs in the empirical analysis. The political fall of Pedro Castillo in 2022 is treated as the beginning of an ongoing sixth critical juncture whose long-term institutional legacy remains unresolved.

Both alternatives are rejected on theoretical grounds. Constitutional dates in Peru are precisely the kind of formal institutional change that does not necessarily produce behavioral change. As Levitsky and Murillo argue, formal rules in weak institutional environments are often repeatedly overturned or rendered ineffective, with actors developing expectations of instability rather than compliance (Levitsky & Murillo, 2009, p. 123). Peru’s constitutional history exemplifies this pattern: thirteen constitutions in two centuries means that most constitutional moments did not produce durable path-dependent change in how political experience accumulates. Using constitutional dates as cut points would risk mistaking formal institutional change for substantive transformation in continuity conditions — exactly the distinction this paper is built to capture.

Regime-type periodization presents a different problem. Classifying historical periods as democratic or authoritarian collapses variation in continuity conditions

into a categorical distinction that is not central to the argument developed here. The theoretical framework focuses on the conditions under which political experience accumulates and is preserved. Those conditions may vary substantially within both democratic and authoritarian settings, depending on the broader configuration of political power, institutional incentives, and mechanisms of ministerial replacement. A regime classification therefore risks obscuring the very dimension of variation this study seeks to identify. By contrast, the epoch framework preserves continuity as the primary analytical dimension, allowing changes in knowledge-accumulation conditions to emerge from the historical trajectory of institutional development rather than from pre-defined regime categories. For this reason, the analysis follows the structural-historical periodization proposed by Lopez Jimenez et al. (2025), which identifies epochs according to the critical junctures that reconfigured the state's political logic rather than according to formal constitutional or regime boundaries.

3.3 Ministerial Spells as Units of Observation

The fundamental unit of observation in this study is the ministerial spell: the uninterrupted period during which an individual occupies a specific cabinet portfolio. A spell begins on the date of appointment and ends on the date of departure — whether by dismissal, resignation, death in office, or the termination of the presidential administration. This definition treats each continuous period of service as a discrete observation, independent of what came before or after. When the same individual serves multiple non-consecutive terms in the same or different portfolios, each appointment is coded as a separate spell. The reason is theoretical: each spell represents a distinct opportunity for continuity and, therefore, for knowledge accumulation.

Duration is defined as the number of days elapsed between the beginning and end of each spell. It is not a measure of performance, influence, or effectiveness. Rather, it is a measure of time — the raw material from which continuity is built or denied. A spell of three hundred days does not tell us that a minister learned, governed effectively, or left the portfolio better than they found it. It tells us only that three hundred days were available for those processes to occur. Conversely, a spell of thirty days indicates that the opportunity for continuity was interrupted at a much earlier stage, regardless of the minister's individual qualities or intentions.

For this reason, the analysis does not evaluate ministers as individuals. Rather, it treats duration as an institutional indicator of the continuity conditions under which ministers were able to remain in office. More specifically, duration provides information at three analytical levels central to the theoretical framework:

- **Within epochs.** When aggregated across all ministerial spells within an institutional epoch, the distribution of durations provides evidence about the continuity conditions under which political experience could accumulate. Longer

durations imply greater opportunities for knowledge accumulation; shorter durations suggest repeated interruption.

- **Between epochs.** When duration distributions are compared across successive institutional epochs, changes in continuity conditions provide evidence about whether critical junctures altered the state's capacity to retain governing experience. Improvements in continuity are interpreted as evidence consistent with institutional learning, while persistent instability suggests its absence.
- **Across portfolios.** When duration distributions are compared across ministries operating within the same epoch, systematic differences provide evidence that some sectors may have been shielded from broader patterns of instability. Such deviations constitute the empirical signature of the protective belt developed in the theoretical framework.

The database covers five portfolios spanning the period from 1821 to 2026, yielding 1,069 individual ministerial spells. The selected portfolios are not intended to represent the entirety of the Peruvian state. Rather, they were chosen because each captures a dimension of state capacity central to the argument developed in this study:

- **Premier:** coordinates cabinet action and sustains the political viability of the executive.
- **Economy:** shapes fiscal policy, macroeconomic management, and the state's investment capacity.
- **Interior:** governs public order, internal security, and coercive capacity.
- **Education:** addresses one of the most persistent citizen-facing public policy challenges.
- **Health:** governs a central welfare portfolio directly linked to citizens' everyday experience of state capacity.

Together, these portfolios capture both the state's capacity to govern and its capacity to address the public problems most visible to citizens according to official national surveys (INEI, 2024). Table 3 summarizes the distribution of spells across portfolios.

Because neither knowledge accumulation nor institutional learning can be observed directly, the analysis relies on ministerial duration as an observable indicator of continuity. The following analytical strategy examines duration patterns within epochs, between epochs, and across portfolios.

Table 3*Ministerial Spells by Portfolio*

Portfolio	Spells	Coverage
Premier	232	1857–2026
Economy	298	1821–2026
Interior	242	1855–2026
Education	213	1837–2026
Health	84	1935–2026
Total	1,069	1821–2026

Source: Author’s ministerial-spell database.

3.4 Analytical Expectations

The theoretical framework developed above generates observable expectations at three analytical levels corresponding to the distinction between knowledge accumulation within epochs, institutional learning between epochs, and the protective belt.

The first concerns variation *within epochs*. If ministerial duration captures continuity conditions, then the distribution of spell lengths within a given epoch provides evidence about the opportunities available for knowledge accumulation during that period. Epochs characterized by longer average durations and lower replacement risks should offer more favorable conditions for the retention and transmission of governing experience. Epochs characterized by short spells and frequent replacement should indicate environments in which knowledge accumulation was repeatedly interrupted.

The second concerns institutional learning *between epochs*. If Peru’s critical junctures produced durable improvements in the conditions governing knowledge accumulation, those improvements should be visible in changes in ministerial duration across successive epochs. Specifically, ministerial spells should tend to become longer and the risk of replacement lower in epochs following critical junctures that successfully altered the underlying political logic. Conversely, if critical junctures repeatedly failed to transform those continuity conditions — if they functioned as near-misses rather than genuine institutional ruptures — duration patterns should remain broadly similar across historical periods despite substantial political and constitutional change.

The third concerns variation *across portfolios*. The protective-belt heuristic suggests that some ministries may partially escape the continuity conditions prevailing in the broader political environment. Where external accountability, technical specialization, or strategic importance raise the cost of ministerial replacement, duration should be systematically longer than the general continuity conditions of the epoch would predict. The presence of such a pattern would not demonstrate institutional learning at the level of the state as a whole. Rather, it would indicate localized environments in which continuity and knowledge accumulation are more effectively

Table 4*Analytical Strategy*

Analytical Question	Evidence Examined	Method
Knowledge accumulation within epochs	Distribution of ministerial durations within each institutional epoch	Descriptive statistics (median, mean, dispersion) and Kaplan–Meier survival estimates
Institutional learning between epochs	Differences in continuity conditions across successive institutional epochs	Kaplan–Meier survival comparisons, log-rank tests, and Cox proportional-hazards models
Protective belt	Differences in ministerial survival across portfolios within the same institutional environment	Kaplan–Meier survival comparisons and Cox proportional-hazards models

protected — islands of relative stability within a broader pattern of institutional interruption.

These expectations do not constitute deterministic hypotheses. Political systems are complex, and ministerial duration reflects many factors beyond the mechanisms identified here. The expectations instead provide a framework for interpreting the evidence. They specify what favorable and unfavorable continuity conditions would look like within epochs, what institutional learning would look like across epochs, and what empirical evidence would be consistent with the existence of a protective belt.

3.5 Analytical Strategy

Table 4 summarizes the relationship between the theoretical framework and the empirical strategy. The analysis proceeds from the description of continuity conditions within institutional epochs, to the comparison of those conditions across epochs, and finally to the evaluation of portfolio-level variation associated with the protective-belt argument.

The first step examines knowledge accumulation within epochs. Descriptive statistics and Kaplan–Meier estimates are used to characterize the distribution of ministerial durations associated with each institutional period. Particular attention is given to median duration because survival data are typically right-skewed and therefore poorly represented by arithmetic means. At this stage, the objective is to identify the continuity conditions that characterized each epoch and the opportunities they provided for knowledge accumulation.

The second step evaluates institutional learning between epochs. Kaplan–Meier survival curves and log-rank tests are used to compare continuity conditions across historical periods. If critical junctures altered the conditions governing knowledge accumulation, those changes should be reflected in systematic differences in survival patterns across epochs. Cox proportional-hazards models provide a more rigorous assessment by estimating whether epoch-level differences persist after accounting for other observable characteristics of ministerial spells.

The third step evaluates the protective-belt argument. Kaplan–Meier estimates and Cox models are used to compare ministerial survival across portfolios. The objective is to determine whether some ministries systematically experience greater continuity than would be expected given the broader institutional environment in which they operate. Persistent portfolio effects would be consistent with the existence of localized mechanisms that shield particular sectors of the state from broader patterns of political instability.

Taken together, these analyses provide an indirect assessment of the theoretical framework. The evidence is interpreted not as proof of organizational learning itself, but as evidence about the continuity conditions from which knowledge accumulation and institutional learning may emerge.

4 Results

4.1 Continuity Conditions Within Institutional Epochs

4.2 Institutional Learning Between Epochs

4.3 The Protective Belt

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